CHAPTER 10

Types of Sentences



Page from the Gutenberg Bible, 15th century

Clauses

Clauses are the building blocks of sentences. A clause is a group of words that contains (at least) a subject and a verb.

Clauses	Not clauses
SUBJECT VERB ecology is a science	to protect the environment
SUBJECT VERB because pollution causes cancer	after working all day

There are two kinds of clauses: independent and dependent.

Independent Clauses

An **independent clause** contains a subject and a verb and expresses a complete thought. It can stand alone as a sentence by itself. An independent clause is formed with a subject and a verb and often a complement.

Subject	Verb	(Complement)
The sun	rose.	
Water	evaporates	rapidly in warm climate zones.

Dependent Clauses

A **dependent clause** begins with a subordinator such as *when, while, if, that,* or *who.* A dependent clause does not express a complete thought, so it is not a sentence by itself. A dependent clause is also called a *sentence fragment.* By itself, it is an incomplete sentence, and it is an error. A dependent clause is formed with a subordinator, a subject, and a verb.

Subordinator	Subject	Verb	(Complement)
. . . when	the sun	rose . . .	
. . . because	water	evaporates	rapidly in warm climate zones . . .
. . . whom	the voters	elected . . .	
. . . if	the drought	continues	for another year . . .

A few of the most common subordinators follow. For a complete list, turn to Appendix C, pages 292–295.

Subordinators

after	before	that	when	which
although	even though	though	whenever	while
as, just as	how	unless	where	who
as if	if	until	wherever	whom
as soon as	since	what	whether	whose
because	so that			

PRACTICE 1

Independent and Dependent Clauses

Remember that an independent clause by itself is a complete sentence, but a dependent clause by itself is an incomplete sentence. Write *Indep.* next to the complete sentences and put a period (.) after them. Write *Dep.* next to the incomplete sentences. The first two have been done for you as examples.

Indep. 1. Globalization means more travel for businessmen and women.

Dep. 2. As business executives fly around the globe to sell their companies' products and services

_____ 3. Jet lag affects most long-distance travelers

_____ 4. Which is simply the urge to sleep at inappropriate times

_____ 5. During long journeys through several time zones, the body's inner clock is disrupted

_____ 6. For some reason, travel from west to east causes greater jet lag than travel from east to west

_____ 7. Also, changes in work schedules can cause jet lag
_____ 8. When hospital nurses change from a day shift to a night shift, for example
_____ 9. Although there is no sure way to prevent jet lag
_____ 10. There are some ways to minimize it
_____ 11. Because jet lag is caused at least partially by loss of sleep, not just a change in the time of sleep
_____ 12. A traveler should plan to arrive at his or her destination as late as possible
_____ 13. Upon arriving, he or she should immediately go to bed
_____ 14. Then the traveler should start to live in the new time zone immediately
_____ 15. Even when the traveler arrives early in the morning and cannot go to bed immediately

Kinds of Sentences

A sentence is a group of words that you use to communicate your ideas. Every sentence is formed from one or more clauses and expresses a complete thought.

The four basic kinds of sentences in English are simple, compound, complex, and compound-complex. The kind of sentence is determined by the kind of clauses used to form it.

Simple Sentences

A **simple sentence** is one independent clause.

Freshwater (s) boils (v) at 100 degrees Celsius at sea level.

Freshwater (s) boils (v) at 100 degrees and freezes (v) at 0 degrees Celsius.

Freshwater (s) and salt water (s) do not boil (v) and do not freeze (v) at the same temperatures.

Notice that the second sentence has two verbs, *boils* and *freezes*. This is called a compound verb. The third sentence has both a compound subject and a compound verb. All three examples are simple sentences because they have only one clause.

PRACTICE 2
Simple Sentences

Use a separate sheet of paper for this exercise.

1. Write two simple sentences with one subject and one verb.
2. Write two simple sentences with one subject and two verbs.
3. Write two simple sentences with two subjects and one verb.
4. Write two simple sentences with two subjects and two verbs.

Compound Sentences

A **compound sentence** is two or more independent clauses joined together. There are three ways to join the clauses:

1. With a coordinator

   Salt water boils at a higher temperature than freshwater, **so** food cooks faster in salt water.

2. With a conjunctive adverb

   Salt water boils at a higher temperature than freshwater; **therefore,** food cooks faster in salt water.

3. With a semicolon

   Salt water boils at a higher temperature than freshwater; food cooks faster in salt water.

Let's study each type of compound sentence in more detail.

Compound Sentences with Coordinators

A compound sentence can be formed as follows:

Independent clause, + coordinator + independent clause

Salt water boils at a lower temperature than freshwater, **so** food cooks faster in salt water.

There are seven coordinators, which are also called coordinating conjunctions. You can remember them by the phrase FAN BOYS (For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So). The following sentences illustrate the meanings of the seven FAN BOYS coordinators. (*Punctuation note*: There is a comma after the first independent clause.)

Coordinators (Coordinating Conjunctions)

To add a reason	
for	Japanese people live longer than most other nationalities, **for** they eat healthful diets.
To add a similar, equal idea	
and	They eat a lot of fish and vegetables, **and** they eat lightly.
To add a negative equal idea	
nor	They do not eat a lot of red meat, **nor** do they eat many dairy products. *Note: Nor* means "and not." It joins two negative independent clauses. Notice that question word order is used after *nor*.
To add an opposite idea	
but	Diet is one factor in how long people live, **but** it is not the only factor.
To add an alternative possibility	
or	However, people should limit the amount of animal fat in their diets, **or** they risk getting heart disease.
To add an unexpected or surprising continuation	
yet	Cigarette smoking is a factor in longevity, **yet** Japanese and other long-lived Asians have a very high rate of tobacco use.
To add an expected result	
so	Doctors say that stress is another longevity factor, **so** try to avoid stress if you wish to live a longer life.

But and *yet* have similar meanings: They both signal that an opposite idea is coming. *But* is preferred when the two clauses are direct opposites. When the second clause is an unexpected or surprising continuation because of information given in the first clause, *yet* is preferred. (*But* is acceptable for both meanings; *yet* for only one meaning.) Compare:

I want to study art, **but** my parents want me to study engineering. (direct opposite)

I am very bad at math, **yet** my parents want me to study engineering. (surprising continuation after "I am very bad at math")

PRACTICE 3

But versus Yet

Which coordinator would you use to connect the two clauses in these sentences? Write either *but* or *yet* in the blank space.

1a. Too much sun damages the skin, _____ many people still do not use sunscreen.

b. Too much sun damages the skin, _____ too little sun also causes health problems.

2a. The company's sales increased last year, _____ its profits declined.

b. The company moved its marketing division to Phoenix, _____ the operations division stayed in Boston.

3a. Population growth has slowed in most developing countries, _____ it has not slowed enough to avoid serious problems.

b. The fertility rate in India has decreased from 6 to 3 births per female, _____ India's population is expanding at the rate of 18 million per year.

PRACTICE 4

Compound Sentences with Coordinators

A. Form compound sentences by adding another independent clause to the following independent clauses. Be sure to write a complete clause containing a subject and a verb. Circle the coordinator and add punctuation. The first one has been done for you as an example.

1. The college campus is located in the center of the city, (so) it is very easy to get there by public transportation.
2. According to the Big Bang Theory, the universe began expanding about 13.7 billion years ago and _____
3. Does the universe have an outer edge or _____ _____?
4. Scientists predict that intelligent life exists somewhere in the universe but _____
5. Mars probes have photographed rocks with water markings on them yet _____
6. We may not be able to communicate with other life forms for _____ _____
7. Instead of taking the psychology final exam, we can write a 10-page research paper or _____
8. I want to write a research paper yet _____
9. Three weeks before the end of the term, I had not started my paper nor _____ _____
10. I needed help choosing a topic so _____ _____

B. For each pair of the following sentences form a compound sentence by joining the two independent clauses with a coordinator that best fits the meaning. Use each FAN BOYS coordinator once. Write your new sentences on a separate sheet of paper, and punctuate them correctly. The first one has been done for you as an example.

1. Nuclear accidents can happen. Nuclear power plants must have strict safety controls.

   Nuclear accidents can happen, so nuclear power plants must have strict safety controls.

2. The accident at the nuclear power plant at Three Mile Island in the United States created fears about the safety of this energy source. The disaster at Chernobyl in the former Soviet Union confirmed them.
3. Solar heating systems are economical to operate. The cost of installation is very high.
4. Energy needs are not going to decrease. Energy sources are not going to increase. (Use *nor* and question word order in the second clause, deleting the word *not*).
5. Burning fossil fuels causes serious damage to our planet. We need to develop other sources of energy.
6. Ecologists know that burning fossil fuels causes holes in the ozone layer. People continue to do it.
7. Developing nations especially will continue this harmful practice. They do not have the money to develop "clean" energy sources.
8. All nations of the world must take action. Our children and grandchildren will suffer the consequences.

C. Write seven compound sentences of your own, using each coordinator once.

Compound Sentences with Conjunctive Adverbs

A second way to form a compound sentence is as follows:

Independent clause; + conjunctive adverb, + independent clause

Salt water boils at a higher temperature than freshwater**; therefore,** food cooks faster in salt water.

Punctuation note: Put a semicolon before and a comma after the conjunctive adverb.

Several transition signals, such as *on the other hand, as a result*, and *for example*, act like conjunctive adverbs; they can also connect independent clauses with a semicolon and a comma. The following chart lists common conjunctive adverbs and a few transition signals that can be used in this way.

Conjunctive Adverbs

To add a similar, equal idea	
also **besides** **furthermore** **in addition** **moreover**	Community colleges offer preparation for many occupations; **also/besides/furthermore/ in addition/moreover,** they prepare students to transfer to a four-year college or university.
as well	Community colleges offer preparation for many occupations; they prepare students to transfer to a four-year college or university **as well.**
too	Community colleges offer preparation for many occupations; they prepare students to transfer to a four-year college or university, **too.**
To add an unexpected or surprising continuation	
however **nevertheless** **nonetheless** **still**	The cost of attending a community college is low; **however/nevertheless/nonetheless/still,** many students need financial aid.
To add a complete contrast	
on the other hand **in contrast**	Tuition at a community college is low; **on the other hand/in contrast,** tuition at private schools is high.
To give an alternative possibility	
otherwise	Students must take final exams; **otherwise,** they will receive a grade of Incomplete.
To add an expected result	
accordingly **as a result** **consequently** **hence** **therefore** **thus**	Native and nonnative English speakers have different needs; **accordingly/as a result/ consequently/hence/therefore/thus,** most schools provide separate English classes for each group.
To add an example	
for example **for instance**	Most colleges now have a writing requirement for graduation; **for example/for instance,** students at my college must pass a writing test before they register for their final semester.

PRACTICE 5
Compound Sentences with Conjunctive Adverbs

A. Form compound sentences by adding a second independent clause to each independent clause. Be sure to add a complete clause containing a subject and a verb. Circle the conjunctive adverb and add punctuation. Some of these sentences are from Practice 4A on page 167. The first one has been done for you as an example.

1. The college campus is located in the center of the city; (therefore), it is very easy to get there by public transportation.
2. According to the Big Bang Theory, the universe began expanding about 13.7 billion years ago moreover _____
3. Students must pay their tuition and fees before they register for classes otherwise _____
4. Scientists predict that intelligent life exists somewhere in the universe however _____
5. Mars probes have photographed rocks with water markings on them nevertheless _____
6. My roommate scored high on the English placement test as a result _____
7. Tuition and fees increase every year for example _____
8. The class thought the teacher would give a test last Friday instead _____

B. On a separate sheet of paper, combine the pairs of sentences in items 3, 5, 6, and 8 from Practice 4B on page 168, using conjunctive adverbs instead of coordinators. Punctuate your new sentences correctly. The first one has been done for you as an example.

1. Nuclear accidents can happen. Nuclear power plants must have strict safety controls.
   Nuclear accidents can happen; therefore, nuclear power plants must have strict safety controls.

C. Write five compound sentences, using each of these conjunctive adverbs once: *in addition, nevertheless, on the other hand, therefore*, and *for instance*.

Compound Sentences with Semicolons

A third way to form a compound sentence is to connect the two independent clauses with a semicolon alone:

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
Poland was the first Eastern European country to turn away from communism;

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
others soon followed.

This kind of compound sentence is possible only when the two independent clauses are closely related in meaning. If they are not closely related, they should be written as two simple sentences, each ending with a period.

PRACTICE 6
Compound Sentences with Semicolons

A. Place a semicolon between the two independent clauses in the following compound sentences.

1. The practice of yoga strengthens the body and promotes flexibility it also strengthens the mind and refreshes the soul.
2. Motherhood causes some women to quit their jobs others continue working despite having young children to care for.
3. Three hundred guests attended his wedding two attended his funeral.

B. On a separate sheet of paper, write three compound sentences of your own, using a semicolon to join the independent clauses.

PRACTICE 7
Editing Practice

Use what you have learned about forming compound sentences to improve the following mini-essay, which contains many short, simple sentences. Combine sentences wherever possible. Try to use each of the three methods at least once. There are many possible ways to combine sentences.

Robots

[1]A robot is a mechanical device that can perform boring, dangerous, and difficult tasks. [2]First of all, robots can perform repetitive tasks without becoming tired or bored. [3]They are used in automobile factories to weld and paint. [4]Robots can also function in hostile environments. [5]They are useful for exploring the ocean bottom as well as deep outer space. [6]Finally, robots can perform tasks requiring pinpoint accuracy. [7]In the operating room, robotic equipment can assist the surgeon. [8]For instance, a robot can kill a brain tumor. [9]It can operate on a fetus with great precision.

[10]The field of artificial intelligence is giving robots a limited ability to think and to make decisions. [11]However, robots cannot think conceptually. [12]Robots cannot function independently. [13]Humans have to program them. [14]They are useless. [Use *otherwise* to combine sentences 13 and 14.] [15]Therefore, humans should not worry that robots will take over the world—at least not yet.

Complex Sentences

A **complex sentence** contains one independent clause and one (or more) dependent clause(s). In a complex sentence, one idea is generally more important than the other. We place the more important idea in the independent clause and the less important idea in the dependent clause.

There are three kinds of dependent clauses: adverb, adjective, and noun. You will study all of these kinds of clauses in greater detail in Chapters 12, 13, and 14.

Complex Sentences with Adverb Clauses

An adverb clause acts like an adverb; that is, it tells where, when, why, and how. An adverb clause begins with a subordinator, such as *when, while, because, although, if, so*, or *that*. It can come before or after an independent clause.

DEPENDENT ADVERB CLAUSE / INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
Although women in the United States could own property, they could not vote until 1920.

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE / DEPENDENT ADVERB CLAUSE
A citizen can vote in the United States when he or she is 18 years old.

Complex Sentences with Adjective Clauses

An adjective clause acts like an adjective; that is, it describes a noun or pronoun. An adjective clause begins with a relative pronoun, such as *who, whom, which, whose*, or *that*, or with a relative adverb, such as *where* or *when*. It follows the noun or pronoun it describes.

DEPENDENT ADJECTIVE CLAUSE
Men who are not married are called bachelors.

DEPENDENT ADJECTIVE CLAUSE
Last year we vacationed in Cozumel, which features excellent scuba diving.

Complex Sentences with Noun Clauses

A noun clause begins with a *wh-* question word, *that, whether*, and sometimes *if*. A noun clause acts like a noun; it can be either the subject or an object of the independent clause.

DEPENDENT NOUN CLAUSE
That there is a hole in the ozone layer of Earth's atmosphere is well known.

DEPENDENT NOUN CLAUSE
Scientists know what caused it.

In the first example, *That there is a hole in the ozone layer of Earth's atmosphere* is the subject of the verb *is*. In the second example, *what caused it* is the object of the verb *know*.

PRACTICE 8
Complex Sentences

A. **Step 1** Underline the independent clause of each sentence with a solid line.
Step 2 Underline the dependent clause with a broken line. One sentence has two dependent clauses.
Step 3 Write *Sub.* above the subordinator. Refer to the list of subordinators on page 163.

The first one has been done for you as an example.

Sub.
1. Because the cost of education is rising, many students must work part-time.
2. When students from other countries come to the United States, they often suffer from culture shock.
3. Because financial aid is difficult to obtain, many students have to work part-time.
4. Please tell me where the student union is.
5. Engineers, who have an aptitude for drafting and mechanics, must also be artistic and imaginative.
6. While the contractor follows the blueprint, the engineer checks the construction in progress.
7. Since the blueprint presents the details of the engineer's plans, it must be interpreted accurately by the contractor.
8. Students should declare a major by their junior year unless they have not made up their minds.
9. Even though students declare a major now, they can change it later.
10. The government says that inflation is holding steady.
11. Economists are concerned that the rate of inflation will double if the government does not take immediate steps to control it.

B. **Step 1** Add a logical independent clause to each of the dependent clauses.
Step 2 Punctuate each sentence correctly.

The first one has been done for you as an example.

1. I cannot register for classes _____ until I pay my tuition.
2. Unless I take 12 units each term _____.
3. _____ that computer engineering is a popular major.
4. _____ who taught this course last term?
5. Because I had to look for a part-time job _____ _____.
6. _____ if I want to get to school on time.
7. _____ whether I should take advanced calculus.
8. _____ whom I met at the math club meeting last week.
9. When I left my country _____.
10. _____ that my college adviser recommends.

Compound-Complex Sentences

A Compound-complex sentence has at least three clauses, at least two of which are independent. You can use almost any combination of dependent and independent clauses. Just be sure that there is at least one independent clause. In the following examples, independent clauses are underlined with a solid line and dependent clauses with a dotted line.

1. I wanted to travel after I graduated from college; however, I had to go to work immediately.
2. After I graduated from college, I wanted to travel, but I had to go to work immediately.
3. I wanted to travel after I graduated from college, but I had to go to work immediately because I had to support my family.
4. I could not decide where I should work or what I should do, so at first I did nothing.

Punctuate the compound part of a compound-complex sentence like a compound sentence; that is, use a semicolon/comma combination (sentence 1), or put a comma before a coordinator joining two independent clauses (sentences 2, 3, and 4).

Punctuate the complex part like a complex sentence. With adverb clauses, put a comma after a dependent adverb clause (sentence 2) but not before it (sentence 3). With noun clauses (sentence 4), use no commas.

PRACTICE 9
Punctuation

Punctuate the following sentences.

Step 1 Underline the independent clauses with a solid line and the dependent clauses with a broken line.
Step 2 Add commas and/or semicolons as necessary.

1. Information and communication technology is reaching out to help people in the poorest countries improve their lives for example fishermen on the Bay of Bengal can now receive online weather reports that tell them when it is safe to go out.
2. Furthermore, when the fishermen bring in a boatload of fish they can find out the current market prices for their fish, which will help them bargain with the middlemen to whom they sell their catch.
3. The cost of the cheapest computer is at least $200 and since this is more than an individual fisherman can afford several fishing villages together can pool their money and buy one to share.
4. The worldwide reach of the Internet is also providing employment opportunities in developing countries and as greater numbers of people learn the technology these opportunities will expand.
5. When you call your U.S. bank you may find yourself speaking to a customer service representative who is sitting in the Philippines or Puerto Rico and when you need technical support for your home computer you will probably get help from a programmer in New Delhi.

Sentence Types and Writing Style

Now that you know the basic kinds of sentences in English, you can develop a good writing style. Writing that uses only one kind of sentence is boring and may not convey the message that you intend.

As you read the model essay, notice the kinds of sentences.

- Paragraphs 1 and 4 have too many compound sentences. This style is boring because so many sentences use *and* as the connector.
- Paragraph 2 has too many simple sentences. This style sounds choppy.
- Paragraph 3 uses a good mixture of sentence types.

MODEL

Problems with Style

Rosa Parks

1 Rosa Parks is a famous African-American woman, **and** she is often called "the mother of the civil rights movement." She was born into a poor but hardworking African-American family in Alabama, **and** no one suspected that she would become the spark that ignited the civil rights movement in the United States. This movement changed U.S. society forever, **and** it helped African-Americans attain equal rights under the law.

2 Parks became famous quite by accident. One day in 1955, she was on her way home from her job in a Montgomery, Alabama, department store. She boarded a city bus with three other African-Americans. They sat in the fifth row. The fifth row was the first row African-Americans were allowed to sit in. A few stops later, the front four rows filled up. A white man was left standing.

3 According to the laws of that time, African-Americans had to give up their seats to whites, so the bus driver asked Parks and the three other African-Americans to get up and move. Although the others complied, Parks refused. She later said she was not tired from work, but tired of being treated like a second-class citizen. The bus driver called the police, who arrested Parks and took her away in handcuffs.

4 Over the weekend, a protest was organized, **and** on the following Monday, African-American people in Montgomery began a boycott of the public buses, **and** the boycott was tremendously successful, **and** it lasted more than a year. The Supreme Court of the United States finally ruled that segregation on public transportation was unconstitutional. African-Americans had won a huge victory, **and** they realized their power to change the system.

Now read the same essay with the sentence structure revised.

MODEL

Revised Essay

Rosa Parks

1 Rosa Parks is a famous American African-American woman who is often called "the mother of the civil rights movement." When she was born into a poor but hardworking African-American family in Alabama, no one suspected that she would become the spark that ignited the civil rights movement in the United States. This movement changed U.S. society forever by helping African-American people attain equal rights under the law.

2 Parks became famous quite by accident. One day in 1955, on her way home from her job in a Montgomery, Alabama, department store, she boarded a city bus with three other African-Americans. They sat in the fifth row, which was the first row African-Americans were allowed to sit in. A few stops later, the front four rows filled up, and a white man was left standing.

3 According to the laws of that time, African-Americans had to give up their seats to whites, so the bus driver asked Parks and the three other African-Americans to get up and move. Although the others complied, Parks refused. She later said she was not tired from work, but tired of being treated like a second-class citizen. The bus driver called the police, who arrested Parks and took her away in handcuffs.

4 Over the weekend, a protest was organized, and on the following Monday, African-American people in Montgomery began a boycott of the public buses. The boycott was tremendously successful, lasting for more than a year. The Supreme Court of the United States finally ruled that segregation on public transportation was unconstitutional. Because they had won a huge victory, African-Americans realized their power to change the system.

PRACTICE 10

Combining Sentences in Different Ways

A. Improve this paragraph, which contains too many compound sentences. Change compound sentences into complex sentences, using one of the subordinators listed. Use each subordinator once. Rewrite the paragraph on a separate sheet of paper.

after　　although　　because　　when

Equal Rights for Women

Russian women started to gain equality earlier than women in the United States. The concept of equal rights and responsibilities for women was part of communist philosophy, so Russians of both sexes had equal access to education and jobs from the beginning of the Soviet Union. The 1937 Soviet constitution declared that women and men had equal rights and responsibilities, but women in the United States do not have legal equality even today. An admendment to the U.S. Constitution giving women equal rights has never been approved. Before World War II, few U.S. women worked outside the home. Millions of men left to become soldiers during the war, and women took over their jobs. Suddenly, women discovered that they could do anything. The men returned home, and women began to demand the equality that they had earned.

B. Use what you know about the different kinds of sentences to improve this short essay, which contains too many simple sentences. Use different methods of combining the sentences. Rewrite the essay on a separate sheet of paper.

Nonverbal Communication

1 Nonverbal communication, or body language, is used everywhere in the world. It is a very powerful means of communication. It communicates much more than spoken words.

2 One example of nonverbal communication is what occurs between parents and child. Parents smile at their child. They communicate love, acceptance, and reassurance. The child feels comfortable and safe. The smile signifies approval. The child is happy and well adjusted.

3 Another example of nonverbal communication is the image a person shows in public. A woman is walking alone on an unfamiliar and possibly dangerous street. She wants to appear confident. She walks quickly. She may be tired. She walks with her shoulders straight and her head held high. Her eyes are focused straight ahead. Someone is looking at her. She returns the glance without hesitation. In contrast, a nervous woman appears afraid. She walks slowly with her shoulders and eyes down.

4 Indeed, body language can express more than spoken language. Merely by raising an eyebrow, clenching a jaw, or softening the eyes, a person can express disapproval, anger, or love. It is a very strong method of communication.

Review

These are the important points covered in this chapter.

1. **Clauses** are the main building blocks of sentences. There are two kinds of clauses: independent and dependent.

   a. An **independent clause**
   - expresses a complete thought.
   - can be a sentence by itself.

   English grammar is easy.

   b. A **dependent clause**
   - begins with a subordinator.
   - cannot be a sentence by itself.
   - is one of three types: adverb, adjective, or noun.

   ADVERB
   . . . because grammar is easy . . .

   ADJECTIVE
   . . . which is in Spanish . . .

   NOUN
   . . . that grammar is easy . . .

2. We build **different kinds of sentences** in English by combining clauses in different patterns.

a. A **simple sentence** is one independent clause.	English grammar is easy.
b. A **compound sentence** is two independent clauses joined by • a coordinator, • a conjunctive adverb, or • a semicolon.	Grammar is easy, so I learned it quickly. Grammar is easy; therefore, I learned it quickly. Grammar is easy; I learned it quickly.
c. A **complex sentence** is one independent and one (or more) dependent clauses.	WITH AN ADVERB CLAUSE Because grammar is easy, I learned it quickly. I learned grammar quickly because it is easy. WITH AN ADJECTIVE CLAUSE One of my favorite films is *Like Water for Chocolate*, which is in Spanish. WITH A NOUN CLAUSE She does not agree that grammar is easy.
d. A **compound-complex sentence** has two independent clauses and one (or more) dependent clauses.	Because grammar is easy, I learned it quickly, but it took me several years to master writing.

3. The type of sentence you write depends on your message. When you want to show that ideas are equal, use more coordinated structures, such as compound sentences. When ideas are not equal, use more subordinated structures, such as complex sentences. Develop a good writing style by mixing sentence types.

CHAPTER 11

Using Parallel Structures and Fixing Sentence Problems



Bread seal of Gaza, Israel

In this chapter, you will learn to use parallel structure to add symmetry and style to your sentences. You will also learn to recognize and repair common sentence problems: fragments, run-ons, comma splices, choppy, and stringy sentences.

Parallelism

Parallelism is an important element in English writing, especially when you are listing and comparing and contrasting items or ideas. Parallelism means that each item in a list or comparison follows the same grammatical pattern. If you are writing a list and the first item in your list is a noun, write all the following items as nouns also. If the first item is an *-ing* word, make all the others *-ing* words; if it is an adverb clause, make all the others adverb clauses.

In the examples that follow, the sentences in the column on the right follow the rule of parallelism.

Not Parallel	Parallel
My English conversation class is made up of Chinese, Spaniards, and some are from Bosnia.	My English conversation class is made up of **Chinese, Spaniards**, and **Bosnians**. (*The items are all nouns.*)
The students who do well attend class, they do their homework, and practice speaking in English.	The students who do well **attend class, do their homework**, and **practice speaking in English.** (*The items are all verbs + complements.*)
The teacher wanted to know which country we came from and our future goals.	The teacher wanted to know **which country we came from** and **what our future goals were.** (*The items are both noun clauses.*)
The language skills of the students in the evening classes are the same as the day classes.	**The language skills of the students in the evening classes** are the same as **the language skills of the students in the day classes.** (*The items are both noun phrases.*)

Notes

1. You may substitute a pronoun for the second "the language skills" in the last example:

   The language skills of the students in the evening classes are the same as **those** of the students in the day classes.

2. All the words in the first item do not always have to be repeated in the second. You may repeat all or some of the words, depending on what you wish to emphasize. The following sentences are both correct:

   Before you write a paper or **before you take a test**, you must organize your thoughts.

   Before you **write a paper** or **take a test**, you must organize your thoughts.

Parallelism with Coordinators: *And, Or, But*

Words, phrases, and clauses that are joined by *and, or*, and *but* are written in parallel form. Notice the parallel structures joined by coordinators in the following sentences.

The Federal Air Pollution Control Administration regulates automobile exhausts, **and** the Federal Aviation Administration makes similar regulations for aircraft.

The states regulate the noise created by motor vehicles **but** not by commercial aircraft.

Pesticides cannot be sold if they have a harmful effect on humans, on animal life, **or** on the environment.

Parallelism with Correlative (Paired) Conjunctions

Use parallel forms with the paired conjunctions *both . . . and, either . . . or, neither . . . nor*, and *not only . . . but also*.

Paired conjunctions are placed directly *before* the elements they join in the sentence. Notice the parallel structures in these clauses joined by paired conjunctions:

A new law provides the means for **both** regulating pesticides **and** ordering their removal if they are dangerous.

Air pollutants may come **either** from the ocean as natural contaminants given off by sea life **or** from the internal combustion engines of automobiles.

If **neither** industry **nor** the public works toward reducing pollution problems, future generations will suffer.

Many people are **neither** concerned about pollutants **nor** worried about their future impact.

At the present time, air pollution is controlled through laws passed **not only** to reduce the pollutants at their sources **but also** to set up acceptable standards of air quality.

PRACTICE 1
Parallelism

A. Two or more items in each of the following sentences are written in parallel grammatical form. Underline the items or ideas that are parallel, and circle the word or words that connect the parallel structures. The first one has been done for you as an example.

1. An ideal environment for studying includes good lighting, a spacious desk, (and) a comfortable chair.
2. You know you are truly fluent in another language when you can calculate in it and when you begin to dream in it.
3. People often spend as much time worrying about the future as planning for it.
4. You can learn a second language in the classroom, at home, or in a country where the language is spoken.
5. My new personal computer is both fast and reliable.
6. My old typewriter is neither fast nor reliable.
7. Ann is growing older but unfortunately not wiser.
8. Young people buy computers not only to do schoolwork but also to play games.
9. If industrial nations continue to burn fossil fuels and if developing nations continue to burn their rain forests, the level of CO_2 in the atmosphere will continue to increase.
10. Before the judge announced the punishment, he asked the murderer if he wanted to speak either to the victim's family or to the jury.
11. The criminal neither admitted guilt nor asked for forgiveness before he was sent to prison.

B. Rewrite the following sentences in parallel form. Underline the part of the sentence that is not parallel and correct it. Remember that you do not have to repeat all the words in the second item. The first one has been done for you as an example.

1. The disadvantages of using a credit card are overspending and <u>you pay</u> high interest rates.
   The disadvantages of using a credit card are overspending and paying high interest rates.
2. Credit cards are accepted by department stores, airlines, and they can be used in some gas stations.
3. You do not need to risk carrying cash or to risk to miss a sale.
4. With credit cards, you can either pay your bill with one check, or you can stretch out your payments.
5. You can charge both at restaurants and when you stay at hotels.
6. Many people carry not only credit cards but they also carry cash.
7. Many people want neither to pay off their balance monthly nor do they like paying interest.
8. Not making any payment or to send in only the minimum payment every month is poor money management.

C. On a separate sheet of paper, write seven original sentences in parallel form, using the following conjunctions one time each. Write sentences on the topics suggested, or choose topics of your own.

and	two weekend activities you enjoy
or	two foods you would not eat/give to a baby
but	one school subject that you excel at and one that you struggle with
both . . . and	two advantages of being bilingual
either . . . or	two places you might spend a month's vacation or a honeymoon
neither . . . nor	two places you would never spend a month's vacation or a honeymoon
not only . . . but also	two reasons to get a college degree

Sentence Problems

In this section, you will learn to recognize and correct some common errors in sentence structure: sentence fragments and choppy, run-on, and "stringy" sentences.

Sentence Fragments

Sentence fragments are incomplete sentences or parts of sentences. Remember that a complete sentence must contain at least one main or independent clause.

Study the following examples of sentence fragments and the suggested methods for correcting them.

1. Because some students work part-time while taking a full load of classes.

PROBLEM This is a dependent clause. It begins with a subordinator (*because*). It does not express a complete thought because there is no independent clause.

TO CORRECT (1) Add an independent clause.

Because some students work part-time while taking a full load of courses, **they have very little free time.**

(2) Delete the subordinator (*because*).

Some students work part-time while taking a full load of classes.

2. For example, the increase in the cost of renting an apartment.
   To live and work for at least a year in a foreign country.

PROBLEM Neither sentence has a verb.

TO CORRECT Rewrite each sentence so that it has a verb.

For example, the increase in the cost of renting an apartment **is** one reason for more people being homeless.

To live and work for at least a year in a foreign country **has** always **been** my dream.

3. Teachers who give too much homework.

PROBLEM This is a noun (*teachers*) + an adjective clause (*who give too much homework*). The noun is the beginning of an independent clause that was never finished.

TO CORRECT Finish the independent clause.

Teachers who give too much homework **are unpopular**.

Always check your own writing for sentence fragments. Pay particular attention to sentences beginning with subordinators (*although, since, because, if, before*, and so on). These are DANGER WORDS! Make sure that every clause beginning with these words is attached to an independent clause.

PRACTICE 2
Rewriting Sentence Fragments

A. Read the following sentences. Mark them *Frag.* if they are sentence fragments, or *Comp.* if they are complete sentences. On a separate sheet of paper, rewrite each fragment to make a complete sentence.

_____ 1. The desire of all humankind to live in peace and freedom, for example.
_____ 2. Second, a fact that men are physically stronger than women.
_____ 3. The best movie I saw last year.
_____ 4. *Titanic* was the most financially successful movie ever made, worldwide.
_____ 5. For example, many students have part-time jobs.
_____ 6. Although people want to believe that all men are created equal.
_____ 7. Finding a suitable marriage partner is a challenging task.
_____ 8. Many of my friends who did not have the opportunity to go to college.
_____ 9. Working during the morning and attending classes during the afternoon.
_____ 10. Because I do not feel that grades in college have any value.
_____ 11. A tsunami that occurred in the Indian Ocean in December 2004, killing more than 200,000 people.
_____ 12. The total energy of the tsunami waves was about five megatons of TNT.
_____ 13. More than twice the total explosive energy used during all of World War II, including two atomic bombs, according to one expert.

_____ 14. Evidence that the wave reached a height of 80 feet (24 meters) when coming ashore along the coastline and rose to 100 feet (30 meters) in some areas when traveling inland.

_____ 15. Despite a lag of up to several hours between the earthquake and tsunami, nearly all of the victims were taken completely by surprise.

B. Read the following short essay. Put brackets [ ] around any sentence fragments you find and mark them *Frag*. Then correct the fragments on a separate sheet of paper.

Women Drivers

1 Sexism[1] extends even into the area of automobile driving, it seems. Believing that they are far better drivers than women. Men consider women drivers incompetent, inattentive, and even dangerous behind the wheel.

2 However, statistics prove that women are, in fact, safer drivers than men. For example, insurance rates. Insurance rates for women are 20 percent lower than they are for men. Another proof is that more accidents are caused by male drivers between the ages of 18 and 25 than by any other group. Also, the greater percentage of accidents involving deaths caused by men. Although women are criticized for being too cautious. They are really just being safe drivers.

3 The reasons for women drivers' safer driving habits can perhaps be found in the differing attitudes of the sexes toward automobiles. On the one hand, women drivers who regard the automobile as a convenience. Like a washing machine. On the other hand, men regard the automobile as an extension of their egos. Using it as a weapon when they feel particularly aggressive. Or using it as a status symbol.

4 All in all, women are safer drivers. Because of their attitude. Men can learn to become safe drivers. If they adopt the attitude that an automobile is merely a convenience.

Choppy Sentences

Choppy sentences are sentences that are too short. Short sentences can be effective in certain situations. For instance, when you want to make an impact, use a short sentence.

> Despite countless doctors' warnings, news stories, and magazine articles about the importance of eating a nutritious, balanced diet, many people resist developing healthy eating habits. Some people just like junk food.
>
> (*A sentence of 25 words is followed by one of 6 words. The second sentence has greater impact because it is so short.*)

[1]**Sexism:** men's belief in male superiority

However, overuse of short sentences is considered poor style in academic writing.

Choppy sentences are easy to correct. Just combine two or three short sentences to make one compound or complex sentence. Your decision to make a compound or a complex sentence should be based on whether the ideas in the short sentences are equal or whether one idea is dependent on the other.

1. If the sentences express equal ideas, use coordination to combine them.

CHOPPY SENTENCES

Wind is an enduring source of power. Water is also an unlimited energy source. Dams produce hydraulic power. They have existed for a long time. Windmills are relatively new.

CORRECTED

Both wind and water are enduring sources of power. Dams have produced hydraulic power for a long time, but windmills are relatively new.

2. If the sentences express unequal ideas, that is, if one sentence expresses a less important idea than the other, use subordination to combine them.

CHOPPY SENTENCES

We must find new sources of energy. Natural sources of energy are decreasing. Solar energy is a promising new source of energy. Solar energy is energy from the sun.

CORRECTED

We must find new sources of energy because natural sources of energy are dwindling. Solar energy, which is energy from the sun, is a promising new source.

PRACTICE 3

Rewriting Choppy Sentences

Improve the following choppy sentences by combining them.

Step 1 Decide what the relationship between the sentences is.

- Do they express equal ideas? If yes, write a compound sentence. Both sentences present the main idea.

Similar or equal idea	**and**
Negative equal idea	**nor**
Opposite idea	**but**
Alternative possibility	**or**
Surprising continuation	**yet**
Expected result	**so**
Reason	**for**

- Is one idea more important than another idea? If yes, go on to Steps 2 and 3 and write a complex sentence.

Step 2 Decide which sentence expresses the most important idea. This will be the independent clause.

Step 3 Then decide what the relationship of other sentences to the main idea is and choose a subordinator that expresses that relationship.

Time	**when, after, as soon as,** and so on
Reason	**because, since,** or **as**
Contrast	**although, whereas,** and so on
Descriptive information	**who, which, that,** and so on

The first one has been done for you as an example. As you can see from the example, there may be more than one way to combine the sentences.

1. (a) Gasoline became expensive. (b) Automobile manufacturers began to produce smaller cars. (c) Smaller cars use less gasoline.

   Equal / (Not equal)?
   Main idea? Sentence (b)
   Relationships: Sentence (a) could be time (when) or reason (because). Sentence (c) could be reason (because) or descriptive information (which).
   Combined sentence: When gasoline became more expensive, automobile manufacturers began to produce smaller cars because they use less gasoline.
   OR
   Because gasoline became more expensive, automobile manufacturers began to produce smaller cars, which use less gasoline.

2. (a) Electric cars are powered solely by batteries. (b) The new hybrid vehicles switch between electricity and gasoline.
   Equal / Not equal?
   Main idea? _____
   Relationship: _____
   Combined sentence: _____

3. (a) Government and private agencies have spent billions of dollars advertising the dangers of smoking. (b) The number of smokers is still increasing.
   Equal / Not equal?
   Main idea? _____
   Relationship: _____
   Combined sentence: _____

4. (a) Some students go to a vocational school to learn a trade. (b) Some students go to college to earn a degree.
   Equal / Not equal?
   Main idea? _____
   Relationship: _____
   Combined sentence: _____

5. (a) The grading system at our college should be abolished. (b) The students do not like getting grades. (c) The instructors do not enjoy giving grades.
   Equal / Not equal?
   Main idea? _____
   Relationship: _____
   Combined sentence: _____
   _____
   _____

6. (a) Education in a free society teaches children how to think. (b) Education in a dictatorship teaches children what to think.
   Equal / Not equal?
   Main idea? _____
   Relationship: _____
   Combined sentence: _____
   _____
   _____

Run-On Sentences and Comma Splices

A **run-on sentence** is a sentence in which two or more independent clauses are written one after another with no punctuation. A similar error happens when two independent clauses are incorrectly joined by a comma without a coordinating conjunction. This kind of error is called a **comma splice**.

RUN-ON My family went to Australia then they emigrated to Canada.

COMMA SPLICE My family went to Australia, then they emigrated to Canada.

The ways to correct these two sentence errors are the same.

1. Add a period:

   My family went to Australia. Then they emigrated to Canada.

2. Add a semicolon:

   My family went to Australia; then they emigrated to Canada.

3. Add a coordinator:

   My family went to Australia, **and** then they emigrated to Canada.

4. Add a subordinator:

   My family went to Australia **before** they emigrated to Canada.

   After my family went to Australia, they emigrated to Canada.

PRACTICE 4
Run-On/Comma Splice Sentences

A. Correct the following run-on/comma splice sentences using the method indicated.

1. A newly arrived international student faces several challenges, for example, he or she has to cope with a new culture.
   a. Add a period: _____
   _____
   b. Add a semicolon: _____
   _____
2. New York City is very cosmopolitan, people from many cultures and ethnic groups live there.
   a. Add a period: _____
   _____
   b. Add a semicolon: _____
   _____
   c. Add a subordinator: _____
   _____
   d. Add a coordinator: _____
   _____
3. Learning a new language is like learning to swim it takes a lot of practice.
   Add a coordinator: _____
   _____
4. Ask for assistance at the reference desk in the library, a librarian is always on duty.
   Add a semicolon: _____
   _____
5. Skiing is a dangerous sport you can easily break your leg or your neck.
   Add a subordinator: _____
   _____

B. Some of the following sentences are run-ons or comma splices, and some are correct. Check each sentence. If it is incorrect, write *RO* or *CS* in the space at the left. If it is correct, leave the space blank. Then, on a separate sheet of paper, correct the incorrect sentences.

RO 1. Two letters arrived on Monday a third one came on Wednesday.
Two letters arrived on Monday; a third one came on Wednesday.

_____ 2. An encyclopedia is a valuable source of information it contains summaries of every area of knowledge.

_____ 3. Because of the rapid expansion of human knowledge, it is difficult to keep encyclopedias current.

_____ 4. A printed encyclopedia becomes out of date almost as soon as it is published also it is quite expensive to purchase.

_____ 5. Online encyclopedias are available to everyone with access to the Internet.

_____ 6. Articles in encyclopedias are written by experts in each subject, who are often university professors.

_____ 7. An editor of an encyclopedia does not write articles he only collects and edits articles written by subject experts.

_____ 8. To find a book on a certain subject, you used to look in a card catalog, to find a magazine article on a subject, you used to look in a periodical index.

_____ 9. Now, most libraries have thrown away their card catalogs, they have computerized catalogs that are much more efficient to use and update.

_____ 10. Many periodical indexes, which list only titles of magazine articles and indicate where to find them, have been replaced by computer indexes, some of which display abstracts[1] and even entire articles instantly.

_____ 11. If you cannot find any information on a subject, you can always ask a librarian to help you, they are paid to assist students.

C. Locate the run-on/comma splice sentences in the following paragraphs. Mark them by writing *RO* or *CS* above them. Then, on a separate sheet of paper, rewrite both paragraphs, correcting the mistakes that you found. There are four errors.

[1]Teachers at Stone Mountain State College give higher grades than teachers at 12 of the 19 other colleges in the state college system, according to a recent report from the State Institutional Research Committee. [2]This report showed that more than one-third of the undergraduate grades awarded in the spring semester 2005 were A's only 1.1 percent were F's. [3]The percentage of A's awarded to graduate students was even higher, almost two-thirds were A's.

[4]While students may be happy to receive high grades, evidence suggests that this trend is having negative consequences. [5]Investigation of the admissions criteria[2] of some graduate and professional schools indicates that the admissions offices of these schools are discounting high grades on the transcripts of SMSC students, this means that an A from SMSC is not equal to an A from other universities. [6]Grade inflation may, therefore, hurt a student from Stone Mountain State College who intends to apply to a graduate or professional school he or she may not be accepted despite a high grade point average.

Stringy Sentences

A **stringy sentence** is a sentence with too many clauses, usually connected with *and, but, so*, and sometimes *because*. It often results from writing the way you speak, going on and on like a string without an end.

To correct a stringy sentence, divide it and/or recombine the clauses, remembering to subordinate when appropriate.

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[1]**abstracts:** summaries
[2]**criteria:** standards by which a judgment is made

STRINGY SENTENCE

Many students attend classes all morning, and then they work all afternoon, and they also have to study at night, so they are usually exhausted by the weekend.

CORRECTED

Many students attend classes all morning and work all afternoon. Since they also have to study at night, they are usually exhausted by the weekend.

OR

Because many students attend classes all morning, work all afternoon, and study at night, they are usually exhausted by the weekend.

PRACTICE 5

Stringy Sentences

Improve these stringy sentences.

1. He enrolled in an intermediate calculus class, but he found it too easy, so he dropped it, and he signed up for the advanced class.

   _____

   _____

2. First-born children in a family often have more responsibility than their younger siblings, and they feel pressure to set a good example, so they often become superachievers.

   _____

   _____

3. Last-born children, on the other hand, often have little responsibility, and they may be pampered as the "baby" of the family, but they are the smallest, and they have to get people to like them, so they often develop superior social skills.

   _____

   _____

4. The students in my engineering class could not do the homework, so we got together and worked for several hours, and we finally solved all the problems.

   _____

   _____

5. The lack of rainfall has caused a severe water shortage, so people have to conserve water every day, and they also have to think of new ways to reuse water, but the situation is improving.

   _____

   _____

Review

These are the important points covered in this chapter.

1. Parallelism

Two or more items joined by coordinating conjunctions and paired conjunctions must be parallel in structure. The same is true of contrasts and comparisons of items. If the first item is a noun, make all others nouns; if it is a phrase, make all the others phrases; if it is a clause, make all the others clauses.

Not Parallel	Parallel
Taking a class on a pass/fail basis is sometimes better than to get a grade of C.	Taking a class on a pass/fail basis is sometimes better than getting a grade of C.
My grandmother not only speaks four languages but also she understands six others.	My grandmother not only speaks four languages but also understands six others.

2. Sentence Problems

The main kinds of problem sentences that students may write are fragments, run-ons, comma splices, choppy, and stringy sentences.

Fragments are incomplete sentences.

Fragment	Corrected
The subject I enjoyed the most in high school.	The subject I enjoyed the most in high school was physics.

Run-ons and **comma splices** are incorrectly joined independent clauses.

Run-On	Corrected
Getting married is easy staying married is another matter.	Getting married is easy, but staying married is another matter.
	OR
Comma Splice	
Getting married is easy, staying married is another matter.	Although getting married is easy, staying married is another matter.

Choppy sentences are sentences that are too short.

Choppy	Corrected
My family left our homeland. Then we lived in a refugee camp. We lived there for several months. Then we got our documents. We traveled to Canada. We live there now.	After my family left our homeland, we lived in a refugee camp for several months. As soon as we got our documents, we traveled to Canada, where we live now.

Stringy sentences are sentences with too many independent clauses.

Stringy	Corrected
My family left our homeland, and we lived in a refugee camp for several months, but finally we got our documents, so we traveled to Canada, and we live there now.	After my family left our homeland, we lived in a refugee camp for several months. As soon as we got our documents, we traveled to Canada, where we live now.

Editing Practice

Edit the following paragraphs for errors in parallel structure and other sentence problems. Identify the problem sentences and correct them. Rewrite the paragraphs on a separate sheet of paper. (*Note:* Not every sentence has a problem.)

The United States: Melting Pot or Salad Bowl?

[1]The United States counts its population every 10 years, and each census[1] reveals that the racial and ethnic mix is changing dramatically, so by the year 2050, the "average" person in the United States will not be descended from[2] Europeans, but the majority of U.S. residents will trace their ancestry[3] to Africa, Asia, the Hispanic world, the Pacific Islands, or the Middle East. [2]Once the United States was a microcosm[4] of European nationalities, today the United States is a microcosm of the world. [3]The United States is no longer considered a "melting pot" society by many of its residents. [4]Instead, many people prefer the term "salad bowl." [5]They use this term to describe U.S. society. [6]U.S. society will soon be predominantly nonwhite. [7]"Melting pot" implies that the different ethnic groups blend together into one homogeneous mixture, "salad bowl" implies that nationalities, like the ingredients in a mixed green salad, retain their cultural identities.

[8]Earlier generations of immigrants believed that they had to learn English quickly not only to survive but also for success. [9]Now, many immigrant groups do not feel the same need. [10]Because there are many places in the United States where you can work, shop, get medical care, marry, divorce, and die without knowing English. [11]For example, Chinatown in San Francisco and New York. [12]Also, Los Angeles has many Vietnamese immigrants and immigrants from Mexico. [13]In addition, many immigrant groups want their children to know their own culture. [14]Many Hispanics, for instance, want their children to learn both English and study the Spanish language in school. [15]They are fighting for the right to bilingual education in many communities. [16]In many communities they are in the majority.

---

[1]**census:** population count
[2]**be descended from:** be the children, grandchildren, etc., of
[3]**ancestry:** a person's origins
[4]**microcosm:** small community representing a large one